



Personal & Confidential

President Barack Obama

Alliance for Collective Empowerment and Development

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Léandre Poplus, Founder

For Our People, By Our People.

ACE

DEAR PRESIDENT OBAMA

My name is Léandre Poplus. I am the founder of the Alliance for Collective Empowerment and Development. You spent eight years inside an institution that by design was built to keep men and women who look like you out. I come to you respectfully, in the hope of leveraging that insider knowledge as guidance to what we are building.

You are the only former President who has stood at the exact intersection where this initiative lives: the tension between operating inside American systems and carrying the full weight of what those systems have done and continue to do to people of color in this country. You have navigated that tension at the highest level any person can. ACE needs that navigation now.

The Alliance for Collective Empowerment is a 25-year initiative to build a network of self-governing, self-sustaining cities for Black and Native American communities on tribal land protected by sovereign law, funded by community capital, governed by a constitutional framework written by the community it serves.

This is not a movement without a map. The enclosed ACE Act is 22 Titles and over 1,600 paragraphs: a founding constitution, a phased 25-year development plan, a tribal engagement strategy, a healthcare system, an education system from kindergarten through medical school, a community finance model, a formal tax equity initiative, and a 33.15 million acre contingency land claim grounded in a per-person calculation of what was promised and broken in 1865.

We are not asking for your public endorsement. We understand the complexity of your position. We are asking for something more valuable: your private assessment of whether this framework is sound, and if you believe it is your willingness to say so to the people whose support will determine whether it is built.

WHY ACE HAD TO BE BUILT

The founding documents of the United States did not accidentally exclude Black and Native people. They excluded us by design, with specificity, and in writing. We do not dispute that. What ACE disputes is the conclusion that the remedy lives inside the same architecture that produced the exclusion. The Constitution is not failing its purpose. It is fulfilling it. We are not surprised. And we are not waiting for it to change. Nor are we asking to change it. Every activist, every movement, every piece of legislation that came before ACE was built on the belief that the system could be made to serve the people it was designed to exclude, operating under the ideal that if enough laws changed, hearts would follow. And many of those efforts produced real and hard-won gains. But no act of Congress, no Supreme Court ruling, no constitutional amendment has ever been able to legislate what lives in the hearts of the people responsible for enforcing it. The law can change. The man holding the law does not have to.

Four hundred years of evidence has made that clear. It is not out of spite, and it is not out of hatred, that ACE builds outside the jurisdiction of a document that was never written with as much as a suggestion of serving our communities. It is out of the only honest conclusion the evidence permits: that the freedom, sovereignty, and dignity Black and Native people deserve cannot be granted by a system designed to deny it. Any system built to truly serve our communities must be built by those communities, on their own ground, under their own authority.

Black institutions are not strangers to having reached the height of their power. Tulsa, Greenwood, The Freedmen's Bureau. Yet these are the very institutions COINTELPRO was designed to destroy. Every time, the system responded to Black success not with recognition but with removal. You understand that pattern better than most, because you governed inside it. ACE was built with that history in mind.

Every legal protection in the ACE Act exists because we studied what happened to what came before us and chose to build accordingly. The question we are bringing to you is not whether this vision is necessary. We believe you already know that it is. The question is whether the architecture is sound enough to survive what will come for it.

That is why we need your counsel, not your endorsement.

THE ASK

Will you help us navigate this correctly?

If you review the enclosed proposal and believe it is serious, legally grounded, and worthy of the attention of the people who have the resources and the influence to make it real a private word from you to any of them changes everything.

If you have concerns about the framework, we want to hear them before we move further. Your knowledge of what can be legally and politically defended, and what cannot, is irreplaceable.

We will follow up through the Obama Foundation within 90 days of this delivery. If you choose not to respond, we will proceed and we will not make your silence public. ACE builds what ACE builds. But we believe you should see this first.

We are not asking you to carry this. We are asking you to tell us if we are carrying it correctly.

We also recognize that decisions of this weight are rarely made alone. If Michelle reads this with you, we hope she reads it closely. She has spent her career thinking about what institutions owe the communities they were built to serve, and her perspective on what ACE is building is one we would not take lightly.

The full ACE Act is enclosed. We would welcome your time.

SUPPORTING LEGAL DOCUMENTATION, AVAILABLE UPON REQUEST

The following documents have been prepared and are available to you upon request:

- **ACE Sovereign Territory Act: Companion Legal Brief v1.0** - Pre-argument legal defense of ACE's contingency land claim across ten states of existing federal public land, grounded in the Continuity Doctrine and the Federally Recognized Indian Tribe List Act of 1994.
- **ACE Submission to the United Nations CERD v1.0** - Formal civil society submission to the Committee on the Elimination of Racial Discrimination's active General Recommendation on reparations for chattel enslavement, filed June 2026.

DIRECT CONTACT

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